

Across Lingala Ghanpur and neighbouring villages, Padmashalis comprise over 90% of artisan households, engaging cooperatively across caste-based roles. Men typically operate looms, while women manage dyeing, tying, and thread preparation, preserving skill continuity through domestic transmission.

Within the village, a hierarchy of artisan roles is evident:

- Master Weavers: Experienced artisans who oversee multiple orders, ensure quality standards, and guide younger or less skilled weavers.
- Sahukars (Middlemen): Local agents who supply raw materials, provide advance payments, procure bulk orders, and bridge village producers with urban markets.

Similar patterns are documented in neighbouring weaver communities such as Siripuram, where Padmashali artisans dominate both demographic and craft systems, often forming dominant caste structures with economic and social influence in the village body politic.



Fig.18. Cotton Ikat saree; photo credits Taniya Bala.

3.3 ROLE AND PROFILES OF ARTISANS

MAHESWARAM RAGHUNANDHAN

GENDER: Male

AGE: 39

OCCUPATION: Weaver



Maheswaram Raghunandhan is a third-generation Ikat weaver from Lingalaghanpur, Telangana. Formerly a master weaver, he managed a team of nine artisans, ensuring the production of quality Ikat textiles from his family's workshop. He is currently part of a government initiative to develop lighter, softer fabrics while preserving the traditional character of Ikat. His work reflects both technical skill and a commitment to adapting the craft to contemporary needs.

MAHESWARAM REVATHI

GENDER: Female

AGE: 27

OCCUPATION: Weaver



Maheswaram Revathi is one of the few women in Lingalaghanpur engaged in weaving, a physically demanding task traditionally undertaken by men. A graduate and mother of two, she works alongside her husband in their home-based workshop, contributing to all stages of the Ikat process, including yarn preparation, dyeing, and weaving. Her involvement supports the continuity of her family's craft while challenging gender norms in the community.

MAHESWARAM SRINIVAS

GENDER: Male

AGE: 40

OCCUPATION: Weaver



Maheswaram Srinivas is a full-time Ikat weaver from Lingalaghanpur, Telangana. His work involves travelling between different locations to complete various stages of the weaving process, a routine he maintains consistently despite the physical and mental demands. This mobility has become an integral part of his practice, driven by a sense of duty and discipline.

Srinivas is also recognised for his support within the weaving community. He readily assists fellow artisans when required and advocates for collective growth. While reserved in manner, he communicates directly when necessary and is regarded as a dependable and respected member of the village's weaving network.

MAHESWARAM SOMAYA

GENDER: Male

AGE: 92

OCCUPATION: Retired Weaver

A quiet witness to the transformation of his community, he began his working life in rice mills labouring with strength and resilience. Over time, he shifted to agriculture, and then, with slow and steady hands, began weaving dhotis at home.

What started as a necessity became a legacy. Through his efforts, and those of others around him, a small practice grew into a weaving community one that continues to thrive today. His journey from field to loom laid the foundation for generations, including his grandson, who now carries the craft forward. Even now, he sits with calm pride, watching the rhythm of the loom continue just as he once began it.



Bitala Uppendra

GENDER: Female

AGE: 35

OCCUPATION: Weaver's Assistant

Bitala Uppendra has been familiar with the Ikat weaving process since childhood, having learnt the skills by assisting family members. Over the years, she has continued to practise these techniques and now passes them on to her own children.

She works alongside her husband, primarily supporting the pre-loom stages such as yarn preparation and dyeing. Her consistent involvement over many years has contributed to the smooth functioning of their home-based weaving practice and to maintaining the quality of their craft.



MAHESWARAM SOMALAKSHMI

GENDER: Female

AGE: 80

OCCUPATION: Retired Weaver

With over 40 years of experience, she has worked on every stage of the Ikat process, weaving silk sarees, cotton fabrics, dhotis, and towels. She has seen the craft evolve, from changes in saree lengths and ply to market prices that once stood at ₹5 per piece.

Her knowledge and skills have been passed on to her children and grandchildren, many of whom are now accomplished weavers. Though retired, she remains connected to the loom and the weaving tradition that has defined her life.

